Aurangzeb's uncompromising forty-nine-year rule is one of those hot potatoes no one wants to touch – except those who have chosen to metaphorically wrap themselves in the saffron-coloured robes traditionally associated with self-sacrifice within Hinduism and who subscribe to the ideology of Hindutva – about which I have more to say in my last chapter. It is precisely because these ideologues have made Aurangzeb's intolerance and Muslim iconoclasm a central pillar of their faith that those opposing them are so reluctant to go near the subject. To my mind, this silence does India's Muslim minority no favours, because it ignores the seismic shift within Sunni Islam that Aurangzeb helped along, whereby power shifted from the secular authorities to the clerics, the *ulema*, with far-reaching consequences.

That process had begun in the wake of the sacking of Baghdad, the capital of the Islamic world, by the Mongols in 1258. In response the theologian now known to his admirers as Shayk-ul-Islam Ibn Taymiyyah called upon all Muslims to return to the pure Islam of *al-salaf al-salih*, the 'pious forefathers', meaning the Prophet and his companions. Ibn Taymiyyah's narrow reinterpretation of Islam is what gave the green light for today's Salafis, Wahhabis and all their offshoots.

The failure of the Mughals and their Muslim allies in India to stand up to the Marathas of the Deccan, leading to Delhi being sacked twice within the space of two years – first by the Marathas in 1737 and then by the Persians in 1739 – led to similar heart-searching among Muslim clerics, among them a student of theology named Shah Waliullah, whose father Shah Abdul Rahim is said to have played a major role in the compilation of Emperor Aurangzeb's *Fatawa al-Hindiya*. Shah Waliullah travelled to Arabia in search of answers and returned home fired with Ibn Taymiyyah's vision of a return to first principles. Coincidentally, he studied in Mecca and Medina at precisely the same time as another student of theology, Muhammad ibn Abd al-Wahhab